Belief State Geometry in Non-Ergodic Transformers: A Mess3 Mixture Experiment

Abstract

We train a small transformer on a non-ergodic mixture of three Mess3 Hidden Markov Model processes, where each training sequence is generated by one component. This construction requires the model to solve two epistemically distinct tasks: identifying which component is active (meta-belief π) and tracking within-component state (η_k). We predict that residual stream activations encode these in orthogonal subspaces (H2). Analysis confirms H2 for the π–η split but not for the η_k–$\eta_{k'}$ structure (overlap 0.53–0.69), which may reflect structural similarity across components or superposition. Training dynamics reveal η_k representations emerge before π, and a capacity pressure analysis confirms that η_k is prioritised over π when dimensions are scarce, with the π–η_k separation preserved even under strong capacity constraints.

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1 Motivation

Real language corpora are *non-ergodic*: each document belongs to one domain or style and never switches mid-document. A model trained on such data must solve two epistemically distinct tasks: identify *which* type of document it is reading (meta-belief π), and track fine-grained structure within that type (within-component belief η_k). We formalise this with a non-ergodic mixture of $K = 3$ Mess3 HMMs, a clean, analytically tractable proxy where ground-truth belief states are computable exactly.

The experimental design is grounded in three prior results:

- Shai et al. [1] show that a transformer trained on a single ergodic Mess3 process encodes belief states as a fractal in the residual stream.
- Riechers et al. [2] prove that non-ergodic pretraining necessarily produces ICL, governed by a synchronisation horizon N^*.
- Shai et al. [3] show that parallel factors are encoded in orthogonal subspaces, a result for simultaneous streams, not temporal mixtures.

This experiment combines the non-ergodic setup of Riechers et al. with the geometry analysis of Shai et al. to ask whether training on a non-ergodic mixture induces a factored residual stream geometry, with π and η_k encoded in orthogonal subspaces.

2 Setup

2.1 Data

Mess3 HMM. A Mess3 process is a 3-state, 3-token edge-emitting Hidden Markov Model parameterised by emission strength $\alpha \in (0.5, 1)$ and mixing rate $x \in (0, 1/3)$. The *token-labeled transition matrix* $T^{(a)} \in \mathbb{R}^{3\times 3}$ encodes the joint probability of emitting token a and transitioning to the next state:

$$T^{(a)}_{ij} = P(\text{token} = a \mid s_t = i) \cdot P(s_{t+1} = j \mid s_t = i),$$

where $P(\text{token} = a \mid s = i) = \alpha$ if $a = i$, else $(1 - \alpha)/2$, and $P(s' = j \mid s = i) = 1 - 2x$ if $i = j$, else x. Sequences are generated by starting in a state drawn from the (uniform) stationary distribution, then at each step emitting a token according to the current state and transitioning to the next state jointly.

Components. We use three Mess3 HMMs with the following parameters (Table 1):

Component	α	x	Character
A	0.95	0.02	Sharp fractal, slow mixing
B	0.80	0.08	Medium fractal, moderate mixing
C	0.55	0.25	Sparse attractor, fastest mixing

Table 1: Mess3 component parameters. α is emission strength; x is the off-diagonal transition probability.

Parameters were chosen so that each component produces a distinct fractal geometry in belief space. Figure 1 shows the Mixed State Presentation (MSP) attractor for each component: the fractal attractor of the belief state iterated function system (IFS).

Sequence generation. To form the training corpus, a component $k \sim \text{Uniform}(\{A, B, C\})$ is sampled for each sequence. A token sequence $x_{1:L}$ of length $L = 16$ (the context window) is then generated from component k alone, starting from the stationary distribution. The context window was set to $L = 16$ to satisfy $N^* < L$ (Section 3.3), ensuring the model accumulates enough context to synchronise to the correct component within a single sequence ($N^* \approx 9.6$). The corpus is *non-ergodic* because sequences never switch components; each sequence is a pure draw from one Mess3 process. Figure 2 shows one example sequence per component; the visual contrast in token diversity across rows reflects the very different α and x values.

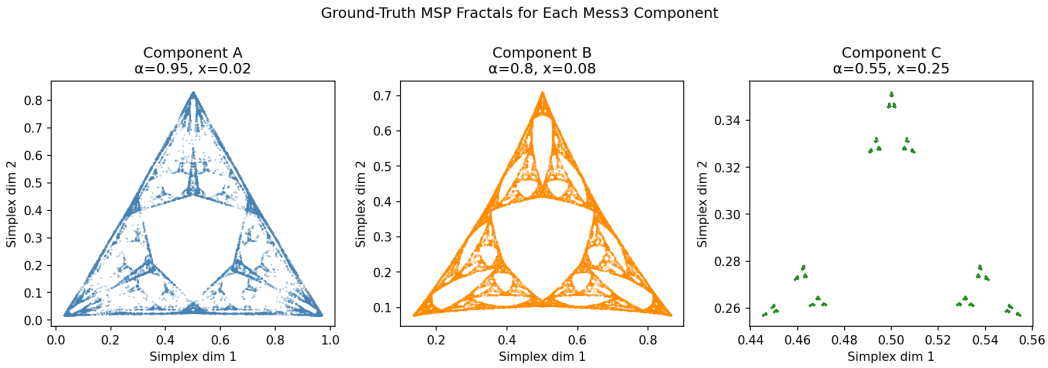


Figure 1: Ground-truth MSP fractals for each Mess3 component, simulated by iterating the IFS $f_a(\eta) = \eta T^{(a)}/(\eta T^{(a)}\mathbf{1})$ for 80,000 steps. Component A (blue) produces a rich self-similar fractal; component C (green) has only ∼9 reachable belief states due to weak emission ($\alpha = 0.55$). These three geometries define the expected residual stream structure under H2.

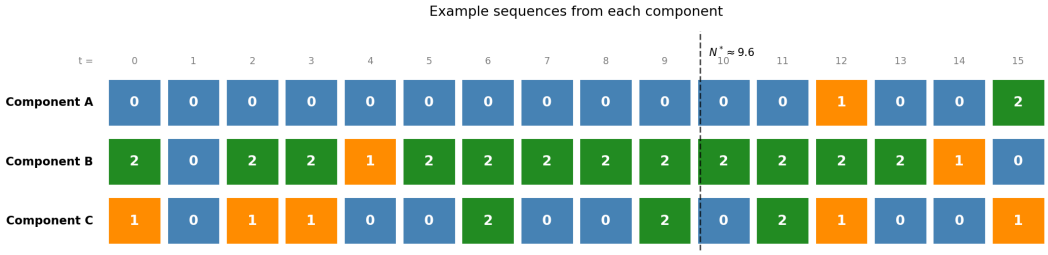


Figure 2: One example sequence (length 16) from each component. Cell color encodes token value (blue = 0, orange = 1, green = 2). Component A ($\alpha = 0.95$) is nearly always token 0; component C ($\alpha = 0.55$) mixes all three tokens freely. The dashed line marks the synchronisation horizon $N^* \approx 9.6$: before this point the identity of the component is ambiguous; after it a Bayesian observer has committed. The contrast in token diversity across rows reflects the components' different emission strengths and makes them distinguishable within N^* tokens.

Ground-truth belief states. At each position t, the Bayesian-optimal agent maintains a joint belief $(\pi(t), \eta_A(t), \eta_B(t), \eta_C(t))$, where $\pi(t) \in \Delta^2$ is the meta-belief over components and $\eta_k(t) \in \Delta^2$ is the within-component belief for component k. Both are initialised to the uniform stationary distribution (which equals uniform for Mess3 by symmetry) and updated after each observed token using the two-step rule (Section 3.3). These analytically computed belief states are stored alongside each sequence and used as regression targets in the geometry analysis. 50,000 training sequences and 5,000 validation sequences were generated.

Figure 3 illustrates the full joint 9-state belief geometry: the meta-belief π lives on the central simplex, while each vertex hosts the MSP fractal of the corresponding component. The three fractals are disconnected, reflecting the non-ergodic block structure.

2.2 Architecture

We use a small GPT-2-style transformer implemented via TransformerLens [4]: 2 layers, $d_{\text{model}} = 64$, 4 heads, $d_{\text{head}} = 16$, $d_{\text{mlp}} = 256$, context window 16, vocabulary $\{0, 1, 2\}$, ≈101k parameters.

2.3 Training

Cross-entropy next-token prediction, AdamW (lr $= 10^{-3}$, cosine decay to 10^{-5}, 1,000 warmup steps), 50,000 steps total. Batch size 256. Sequences are generated on-the-fly each step to prevent overfitting. Checkpoints saved at steps 100, 500, 1,000, 2,000, then every 5,000 steps; at each

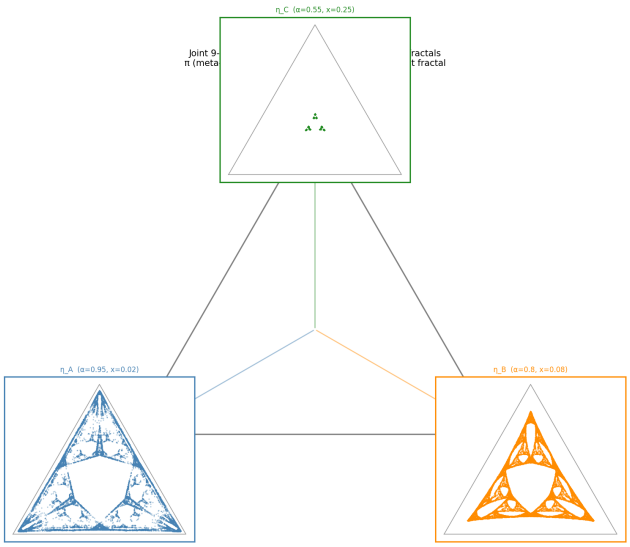


Figure 3: Joint 9-state belief geometry. The centre shows the meta-belief π simplex (which component?); each vertex hosts the MSP fractal attractor of that component (where within?). The three fractals are disconnected (no probability mass flows between components), reflecting the non-ergodic block structure of the corpus.

checkpoint we run regression at the final layer and final position to track how R^2 evolves over training.

3 Hypotheses and Predictions

3.1 Possible Hypotheses

H1 (Joint): The transformer represents η_{joint} as one undifferentiated 8D blob. High R^2 for all targets, but projecting out the π subspace substantially degrades η_k regression.

H2 (Factored): Four orthogonal subspaces: one 2D π subspace and three 2D η_k subspaces. Projecting out π leaves η_k $R^2 \approx$ unchanged.

H3 (Superposition): π and η_k recoverable approximately but packed into fewer than 8 effective dimensions via near-orthogonal superposition.

3.2 Intuitive Prediction

Our geometric intuition is that the residual stream should mirror the ground-truth joint belief geometry: the *nested fractal* shown in Figure 3, with π occupying a central simplex and each vertex of that simplex hosting the MSP fractal attractor of the corresponding component.

We favour H2 (Factored) by analogy to Shai et al. [3], where the setting is a *parallel* joint process: at each timestep independent subprocesses each emit a token and the observation is their concatenation. Our setup is *sequential* (each sequence comes from one subprocess), but the underlying math is the same: block-diagonal transition matrices, conditionally independent factors, and a belief space that decomposes into orthogonal subspaces. If transformers learn factored representations in the parallel case, we expect them to do so here too. We therefore pre-register H2: π and each η_k are encoded in mutually orthogonal residual stream subspaces, with CEV dimensionality ≈ 8 (four 2D subspaces: one for π, one each for η_A, η_B, η_C).

Predicted context-position dynamics. $R^2(\eta_k)$ should be high from the first token, since within-component belief updates begin immediately. $R^2(\pi)$ should start near zero (no information to distinguish components) and rise toward 1 around the synchronisation horizon $N^* \approx 10$, once enough tokens have been observed to distinguish components' emission statistics. Before N^*, the

meta-belief is uncertain and contributes little predictable structure; after N^*, it collapses near a simplex vertex.

Predicted layer dynamics. Layer 0 should encode a rough, partially mixed representation (both π and η_k present but not cleanly separated). Layer 1 should refine this: higher R^2 across all targets, with crisper subspace separation as the second layer's MLP and attention have the opportunity to orthogonalise the representation.

3.3 Mathematical Derivation

The joint belief state. The joint hidden state space is $\mathcal{S}_{\text{joint}} = \mathcal{S}_A \sqcup \mathcal{S}_B \sqcup \mathcal{S}_C$ (9 states). The joint token-labeled transition matrices are block-diagonal:

$$T^{(x)}_{\text{joint}} = \text{diag}\Big(T^{(x)}_A,\, T^{(x)}_B,\, T^{(x)}_C\Big)\,.$$

The zeros off the block diagonal encode non-ergodicity exactly: no probability mass can flow between components. This block structure means the joint belief state $\eta_{\text{joint}} \in \Delta^8$ (the 9-state probability simplex, affine dimension 8) decomposes uniquely as

$$\eta_{\text{joint}}[k, s] = \pi_k \cdot \eta_k[s],$$

where $\pi \in \Delta^2$ is the *meta-belief* and $\eta_k \in \Delta^2$ is the *within-component belief*.

The two-step update. Upon observing token x:

$$L_k(x) = \eta_k \cdot T^{(x)}_k \cdot \mathbf{1} \quad \text{(per-component likelihood)}, \tag{1}$$

$$\pi'_k = \frac{\pi_k \cdot L_k(x)}{\sum_j \pi_j L_j(x)} \quad \text{(meta-belief Bayes update)}, \tag{2}$$

$$\eta'_k = \frac{\eta_k \cdot T^{(x)}_k}{L_k(x)} \quad \text{(within-component Bayes update)}. \tag{3}$$

Crucially, equation (3) applies the standard single-Mess3 update *independently* to each component. The components couple only through the normalisation constant in (2).

Synchronisation horizon. The *synchronisation horizon* N^* is the characteristic number of tokens required for the meta-belief $\pi(t)$ to collapse near the vertex of the true component, given by

$$N^* = \frac{1}{\min_{k \neq k'} D_{\text{KL}}(P_k \| P_{k'})},$$

where D_{KL} is estimated empirically via per-token log-likelihood ratios over long sequences. With the chosen parameters, $N^* \approx 9.6 < 16$, so synchronisation completes within every training sequence.

4 Methods

PCA and CEV dimensionality. To measure how many dimensions the transformer uses to represent the belief state, we run PCA on the matrix of all residual stream vectors per layer, flattening sequences and positions into rows to obtain an $(N \cdot L) \times d_{\text{model}}$ matrix. The principal components are ordered by variance explained. The **CEV (cumulative explained variance) dimensionality** at threshold p is the smallest d such that the top-d components together explain $\geq p\%$ of total variance: the minimum number of directions needed to capture $p\%$ of the structure in the activations.

Regression-based subspace identification [1]. We fit a linear map $W \in \mathbb{R}^{3 \times d_{\text{model}}}$ from residual stream activations $\mathbf{a} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_{\text{model}}}$ (normalised to zero mean and unit variance per dimension) to ground-truth belief targets $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^3$ (either π or η_k) via Ridge regression ($\lambda = 10^{-4}$), and measure linear decodability by R^2 on a held-out 20% test split (fit on 80%). To identify *where* in the residual stream the belief is encoded, we decompose $W = U\Sigma V^\top$, where the columns of V are orthonormal directions in activation space ordered by their contribution to the prediction. Since belief states live on a 2-simplex (affine dimension 2), we take the top-2 columns of V as the belief-encoding subspace. This basis is used in all subsequent overlap tests.

Subspace overlap metric [3]. Given two subspaces with orthonormal bases $Q_A \in \mathbb{R}^{k_A \times d}$ and $Q_B \in \mathbb{R}^{k_B \times d}$ (orthonormal rows), the overlap is

$$\text{overlap}(Q_A, Q_B) = \frac{\|Q_A Q_B^\top\|_F}{\sqrt{k_A \cdot k_B}}.$$

The (i, j) entry of $Q_A Q_B^\top$ is the cosine $\cos\theta_{ij}$ between the i-th basis vector of Q_A and the j-th basis vector of Q_B; the Frobenius norm is the square root of the sum of their squares, and dividing by $\sqrt{k_A k_B}$ normalises to $[0, 1]$ (0 = orthogonal subspaces, 1 = identical subspaces).

Fractal visualisation. We visualise whether the residual stream encodes the full fractal geometry of each component's belief attractor, not merely a summary statistic. For each component k, we take residual stream activations from component-k sequences at positions $t > N^*$ (after the meta-belief π has collapsed, so activations reflect pure component-k belief states), apply the η_k regression map to obtain predicted $\hat{\eta}_k \in \mathbb{R}^3$, and plot the resulting point cloud in barycentric simplex coordinates. We compare this cloud against the ground-truth MSP attractor, generated by iterating the IFS $f_a(\eta) = \eta T^{(a)} / (\eta T^{(a)} \mathbf{1})$ for 80,000 steps.

5 Results

5.1 PCA Dimensionality

Layer	CEV (95%)	CEV (98%)	CEV (100%)	Predicted
0	6	9	64	8
1	5	7	64	8

Table 2: PCA dimensionality per layer. CEV(p%) = fewest components explaining $\geq p$% of variance. The first 5–6 dims capture 95%, 7–9 capture 98%, and all 64 carry non-zero variance, revealing a low-dimensional dominant subspace atop a long noise tail.

Table 2 reveals a striking compression: the transformer uses fewer dimensions than the theoretical belief space requires. Theory predicts 8 dimensions (four 2D subspaces), yet 98% of variance is captured in just 7 dimensions at the final layer, and 95% in only 5 (Figure 4).

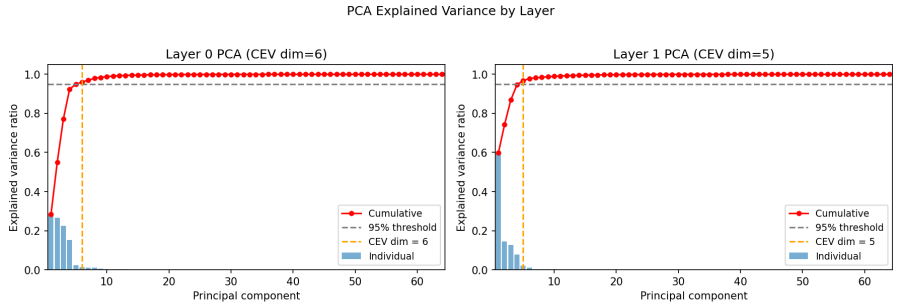


Figure 4: Cumulative explained variance (CEV) by context position, for Layer 0 (dashed) and Layer 1 (solid). The predicted 8 dimensions under H2 are marked by the dotted vertical line. Layer 1 explains 95% of variance in just 5 components, more compressed than the theoretical minimum, consistent with fractal sparsity and superposition.

This compression is interesting in its own right, and we flag it as an open question for future work.

One possible explanation is that the Mess3 dynamics only visit a sparse subset of the belief simplex: rather than covering the full triangle of possible belief states, trajectories trace the MSP attractor, a self-similar curve that occupies fewer than 2 effective dimensions. PCA captures this sparse structure directly, requiring fewer components than the full 2D subspace would demand. Component C is an extreme case: with $\alpha = 0.55$, only $\sim$9 belief states are reachable, effectively reducing η_C to a near-discrete structure that contributes almost nothing to the PCA dimension count. At 100%

CEV both layers require all 64 dimensions, confirming a sharp transition between the dominant low-dimensional belief subspace and a long tail of noise dimensions.

An alternative to fractal sparsity is *superposition* [5]: the model actively packs multiple belief dimensions into shared, near-orthogonal directions, achieving compression through representational overlap. These two explanations are mechanistically distinct and have different implications: fractal sparsity would persist regardless of architecture or training procedure, while superposition would be sensitive to capacity constraints and regularisation. We do not have enough evidence to distinguish between them here; this hypothesis resurfaces in the orthogonality analysis (Section 5) and discussion (Section 7).

5.2 Linear Decodability

Quantity	R^2
π (meta-belief)	0.957
η_A (component A)	0.950
η_B (component B)	0.963
η_C (component C)	0.984

Table 3: Ridge regression R^2 at the final layer, final context position (position 15).

All belief targets are linearly decodable with $R^2 > 0.95$, confirming that the residual stream encodes the full joint belief state.

Figure 5 shows R^2 as a function of context position. $R^2(\eta_k)$ is near 1.0 from position 1, confirming that within-component belief is encoded reliably from the very first token. $R^2(\pi)$ starts at 0 (no context at position 1) and rises sharply to near 1.0 by position 2, remaining stable thereafter. The aggregate $R^2(\pi) = 0.956$ in Table 3 reflects this stability averaged over all positions.

This early rise indicates the model has learned the emission statistics of each component during training. The first token is already highly diagnostic: token 0 is emitted with probability $\alpha_A = 0.95$ under component A but only ≈ 0.3 under component C, so the Bayesian posterior over components shifts substantially after a single observation. The model encodes this partial posterior accurately and immediately.

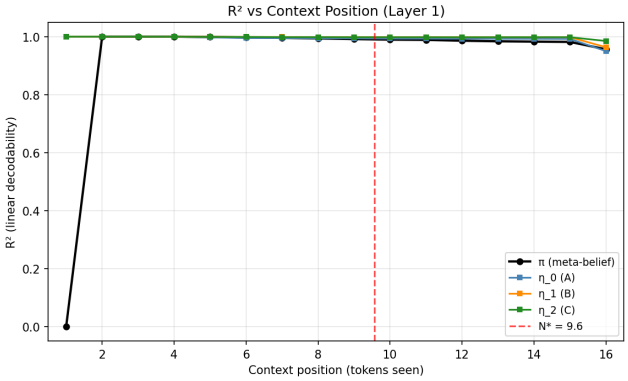


Figure 5: R^2 vs. context position for Layer 1. $R^2(\eta_k)$ (coloured) is near 1.0 from position 1. $R^2(\pi)$ (black) starts at 0 and rises sharply to near 1.0 by position 2, then declines gradually to 0.96 at the final position.

Layer comparison. Figure 6 shows R^2 heatmaps across both layers and all positions. At Layer 0, $R^2(\pi)$ rises sharply at early positions but then *declines* substantially—from near 1.0 at position 2 to ≈ 0.53 at position 14—before partially recovering at the final position. At Layer 1, $R^2(\pi)$ follows the same early rise but remains high throughout (> 0.95), declining only gently to 0.96 at the final position. This suggests Layer 0 encodes a raw, position-entangled representation of π that degrades as context accumulates and the representation becomes increasingly nonlinear; Layer 1 refines

this into a stable, linearly decodable encoding. The η_k encoding is uniformly high at both layers ($R^2 > 0.99$ at all positions except the final), confirming that within-component belief is robustly encoded throughout.

The gradual decline in $R^2(\pi)$ at the final position (0.96 at Layer 1 vs. near 1.0 at early positions) is noteworthy. One explanation is that the model's final-position representations are optimised for next-token prediction, which requires integrating π with η_k in a way that may not be purely linear in the belief coordinates.

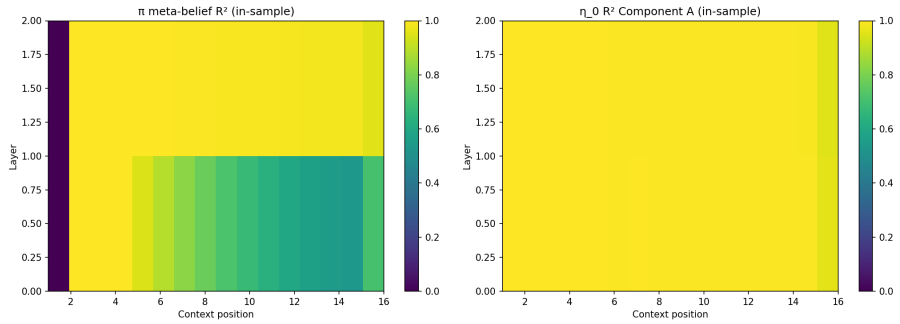


Figure 6: R^2 heatmaps for π and η_k across layers (rows) and context positions (columns). Layer 0 shows strong π encoding at early positions that degrades with context length; Layer 1 maintains high R^2 throughout. η_k is uniformly high at both layers.

5.3 Subspace Orthogonality

	π	η_A	η_B	η_C
π	1.000	0.193	0.171	0.176
η_A	0.193	1.000	0.691	0.534
η_B	0.171	0.691	1.000	0.590
η_C	0.176	0.534	0.590	1.000

Table 4: Subspace overlap matrix ($0 =$ orthogonal, $1 =$ identical). π is nearly orthogonal to all η_k subspaces (0.17–0.19). The η_k subspaces overlap each other moderately, reflecting the shared token alphabet.

π is nearly orthogonal to all η_k subspaces (overlap 0.17–0.19). The moderate η_k–$\eta_{k'}$ overlap (0.53–0.69) could reflect two non-exclusive explanations. First, all three components share the same 3-token alphabet and the same simplex geometry, so their belief directions may be structurally similar regardless of how the model organises them. Second, the model may be packing the three η_k into shared dimensions via superposition [5]. The data are consistent with both; we cannot distinguish them here.

As a direct functional test, removing the π subspace from activations and re-running η_k regression yields R^2 drops of less than 0.001 in all cases, and removing any η_k subspace leaves π regression unchanged, confirming that the subspaces are functionally independent, not merely geometrically near-orthogonal.

5.4 Fractal Geometry

Figure 7 shows, for each component, the ground-truth belief state trajectories (left) and the predicted η_k obtained by applying the regression weights to residual stream activations (right), both plotted in barycentric simplex coordinates.

The regression output faithfully reproduces the fractal structure of each component's MSP attractor, confirming that the model encodes the full geometric structure of the belief distribution, not merely its mean. Component A exhibits a rich self-similar fractal; component B a moderately nested fractal; component C a sparse set of $\sim$9 discrete clusters.

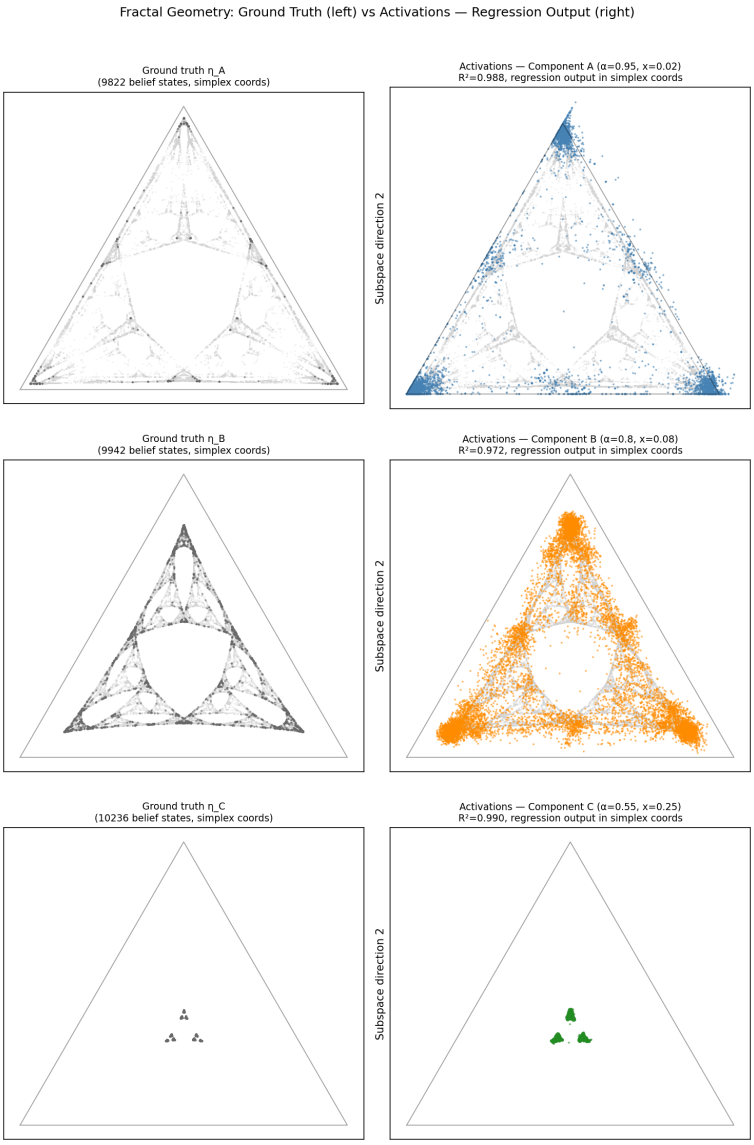


Figure 7: Fractal comparison for each component: ground-truth η_k trajectories (left) vs. regression-predicted η_k from residual stream activations (right), plotted in barycentric simplex coordinates. The regression output reproduces the MSP fractal geometry.

5.5 Training Dynamics

Figure 8 shows that η_k subspaces emerge first and are already near their final quality by step 100 ($R^2 > 0.91$), while π starts at a lower baseline ($R^2 = 0.65$) and improves over a longer timescale: 0.84 at step 500, 0.92 at step 2,000, and 0.96 at step 50,000. Both representations are present from early training, but their convergence rates differ by roughly an order of magnitude.

This ordering suggests the model first learns the per-component Mess3 update rule (which reduces loss immediately for any sequence), and then gradually improves its ability to *distinguish* which component is active (which requires comparing cross-component likelihoods and only helps once the within-component structure is already learned).

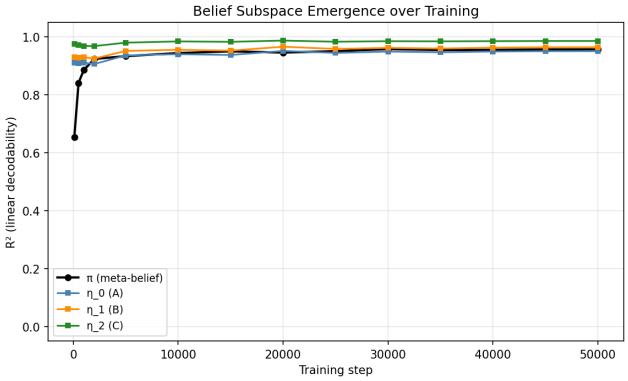


Figure 8: R^2 of π and η_k regressions over training steps (final layer, final position). η_k representations emerge early (step 100, $R^2 > 0.91$). π is already partially encoded at step 100 ($R^2 = 0.65$) but saturates more slowly, reaching 0.92 by step 2,000 and continuing to improve gradually to 0.96 by step 50,000.

5.6 Vary-One Analysis

Motivation. The vary-one analysis tests whether the learned η_k subspaces are *component-specific*. Under H2, each η_k should live in its own 2D subspace. Fitting the η_k regression on only component-k sequences (fixing component identity, varying within-component positions) reveals whether the model has learned three distinct fractal geometries or one shared one. If the cross-component subspace overlap is low, each component occupies a distinct region of residual stream space.

Results.

Component	Within-component η_k R^2
A	0.990
B	0.962
C	0.980

Table 5: Vary-one R^2: regression fit using only sequences from component k.

Within-component R^2 is high for all components (≥ 0.96, Table 5), confirming that sequences from the same component share a coherent subspace structure. For component A the single-component fit is notably better (0.990 vs. 0.950), while for B and C the difference is small, likely because their more uniform attractors are already well-characterised by the global fit.

	A	B	C
A	1.000	0.275	0.208
B	0.275	1.000	0.510
C	0.208	0.510	1.000

Table 6: Cross-component subspace overlap from vary-one analysis. A and C are nearly orthogonal (0.208); A–B and B–C show moderate overlap, likely due to similar emission statistics.

The cross-component overlaps (Table 6) are substantially lower than the η_k–$\eta_{k'}$ overlaps in the global analysis (Table 4), especially for A–C (0.208 vs. 0.534). This confirms that the transformer has learned *component-specific* fractal geometries: the high η_k–$\eta_{k'}$ overlap in Table 4 is inflated by the global regression mixing data from all components, while the vary-one analysis isolates the true per-component subspaces. Component B's moderate overlap with both A and C likely reflects its intermediate emission strength ($\alpha = 0.80$), making its belief geometry somewhat "between" those of A and C.

6 Belief State Priority Under Capacity Pressure

Motivation. The main experiment uses $d_{\text{model}} = 64$, giving the model roughly $8\times$ more residual stream dimensions than the theoretical minimum for a full factored representation ($K + 1$ subspaces of 2D each $= 8$ dimensions for $K = 3$). One might worry that the near-orthogonality of π and η_k subspaces at $d = 64$ is an artifact of surplus capacity: with abundant dimensions, the model can afford to separate them without any inductive pressure to do so. We ask whether factored representations persist when capacity is severely constrained, and which belief state the model sacrifices first when it cannot represent both.

Setup. We train four additional models with $d_{\text{model}} \in \{2, 4, 6, 8\}$, keeping all other hyperparameters fixed (2 layers, $n_{\text{heads}} \times d_{\text{head}} = d_{\text{model}}$ throughout). Each model is trained for 20,000 steps; val loss converges to within 0.001 of the $d = 64$ baseline for all $d \geq 6$, confirming that differences in R^2 reflect representational capacity rather than training quality. $d = 8$ is the theoretical minimum for a full factored representation ($K + 1$ orthogonal 2D subspaces $= 8$ dimensions).

Results.

d	$R^2(\pi)$	$R^2(\eta_A)$	$R^2(\eta_B)$	$R^2(\eta_C)$	CEV dim
2	-0.003	0.384	0.387	0.449	2
4	0.148	0.795	0.820	0.851	3
6	0.649	0.771	0.799	0.745	4
8	0.686	0.830	0.853	0.865	4
64	0.957	0.950	0.963	0.984	5

Table 7: Held-out R^2 for all belief state targets and PCA CEV dimensionality, at the final layer and final context position.

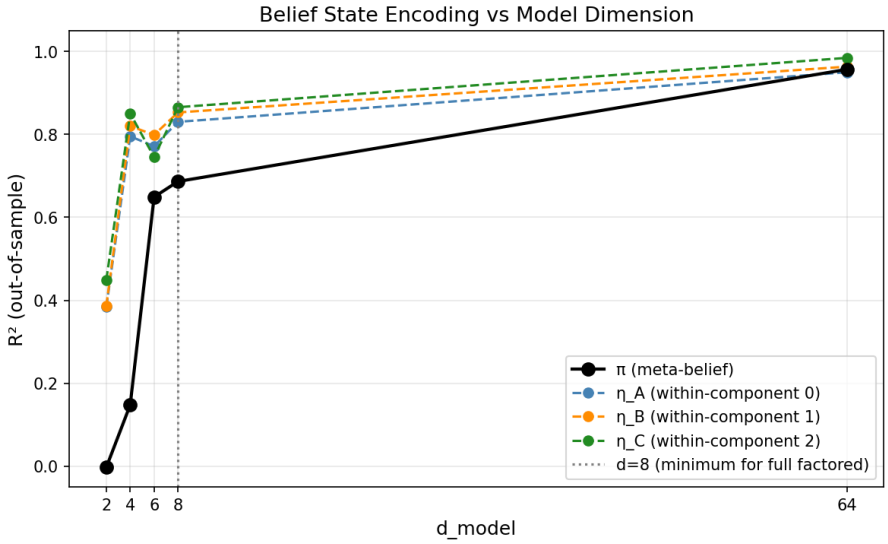
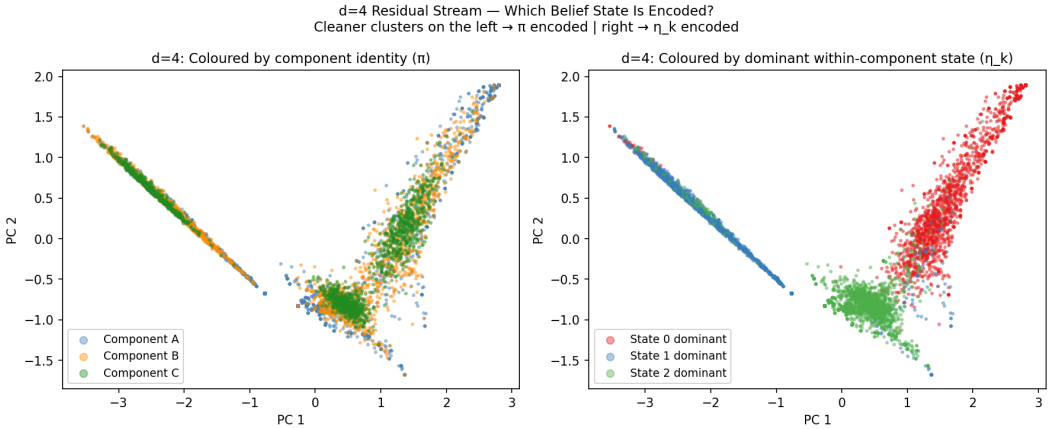


Figure 9: Held-out R^2 vs. d_{model} for all belief state targets. η_k (dashed) achieves $R^2 \approx 0.80$–0.85 by $d = 4$ and improves further to $d = 64$; π (solid black) lags throughout, reaching only 0.69 at $d = 8$ and 0.957 at $d = 64$. The dotted line marks $d = 8$, the minimum dimension for a full factored representation ($K + 1$ orthogonal 2D subspaces).

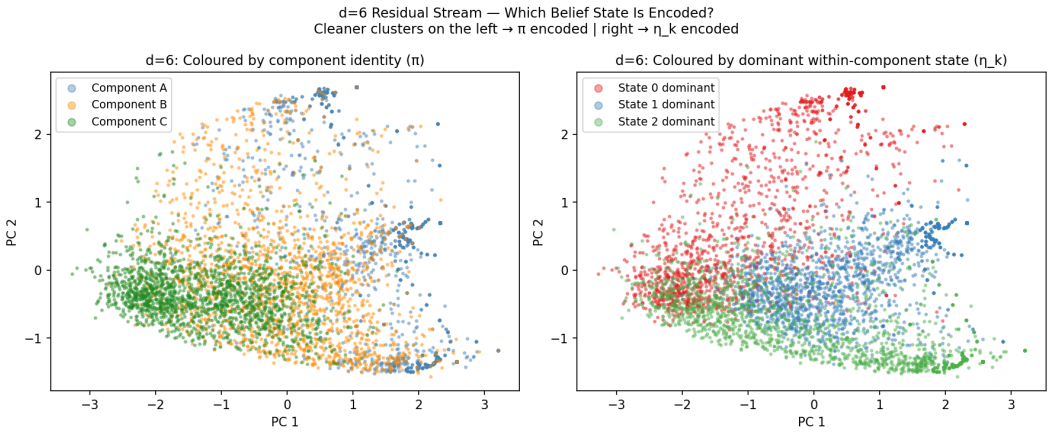
Across all sub-saturating model sizes, η_k is encoded substantially better than π. The two curves in Figure 9 diverge immediately: at $d = 4$, $R^2(\eta_k)$ reaches 0.80–0.85 while $R^2(\pi)$ is only 0.15. At $d = 2$, $R^2(\pi) = -0.003$, indicating that no linear function of the residual stream explains π better than the constant predictor, while $R^2(\eta_k) = 0.38$–0.45. The η_k belief simplex is itself 2-dimensional, so the model is filling its entire residual stream with within-component beliefs and leaving nothing for π. The model prioritises η_k over π across the capacity range tested: the gap is present at $d = 2$

and remains substantial at $d = 8$, where $R^2(\pi) = 0.69$ while $R^2(\eta_k) \geq 0.83$, consistent with the mechanisms outlined above.

The scatter plots in Figure 10 confirm this geometrically. At $d = 4$, PC projections coloured by component identity (left) show largely overlapping clouds (consistent with $R^2(\pi) = 0.15$), while the same projections coloured by dominant within-component state (right) form clean diagonal bands.



(a) $d = 4$: overlapping component clouds (left, $R^2(\pi) = 0.15$); clear within-component bands (right).



(b) $d = 6$: first signs of component separation (left, $R^2(\pi) = 0.65$); within-component bands preserved (right).

Figure 10: Residual stream PCA projections coloured by component identity (left) and dominant within-component state (right).

At $d = 6$, the first signs of component separation appear, but $R^2(\eta_k)$ drops relative to $d = 4$, with the magnitude varying across components: η_C drops 0.106 ($0.851 \rightarrow 0.745$), while η_A and η_B drop ≈ 0.02. This coincides with $R^2(\pi)$ jumping from 0.148 to 0.649, evidence for active subspace competition: the model recruits dimensions for π that previously served η_k, transiently degrading within-component encoding. The η_C dip is most severe, consistent with its attractor being sparse and therefore most sensitive to directional interference. By $d = 8$, capacity is sufficient that both representations recover without mutual compression. Notably, the suppression of π at small d does not involve blending it with η_k: the two are kept in separate directions even at $d = 4$, ruling out the possibility that the near-orthogonality observed at $d = 64$ is an artifact of surplus capacity.

7 Discussion

7.1 Which Hypothesis Best Fits?

The picture is mixed: H2 holds cleanly for the π–η split but not for the internal structure of the η_k subspaces.

H2 confirmed for π vs. η_k. The projection tests are decisive: removing the π subspace from activations causes R^2 drops of less than 0.001 for all η_k targets, and removing any η_k subspace leaves π regression unchanged. The π–η_k subspace overlaps (0.17–0.19) confirm near-orthogonality. The transformer has cleanly separated meta-belief from within-component belief into distinct residual stream directions.

H2 not confirmed for η_k vs. $\eta_{k'}$. H2 predicts four mutually orthogonal subspaces, but the three η_k subspaces overlap substantially with each other (0.53–0.69). This is more consistent with H3 (Superposition): the model does not dedicate a separate 2D subspace to each component's fractal, but instead packs the three within-component beliefs into a shared, partially overlapping region of residual stream space.

The pre-registered prediction (CEV dimensionality ≈ 8) was not confirmed: both layers use only 5–6 dimensions to explain 95% of variance, consistent with the compressed η_k representation described above.

A notable surprise in the training dynamics: within-component beliefs (η_k) emerge early (step 100, $R^2 > 0.9$), while the meta-belief (π) lags behind (step 2,000). This suggests the model first learns to track per-component token statistics (which reduces loss immediately) and only subsequently learns to distinguish *which* component is active (which requires cross-component comparison).

7.2 Implications

Non-ergodic pretraining induces partial factoring. The transformer cleanly separates "what component am I in?" (π) from "where within this component am I?" (η) without explicit supervision. However, the three within-component beliefs are not further separated from each other; they share residual stream directions, suggesting that factoring happens at the coarsest level of the hierarchy (meta vs. within) but not below it.

Training dynamics follow a two-phase ordering. Within-component geometry is learned first and meta-belief routing emerges second; the ordering reflects loss reduction efficiency, not conceptual priority.

7.3 Limitations

The model is small ($d = 64$) with a short context window ($L = 16$), and whether these results generalise to larger architectures remains an open question. The symmetric 3-state/3-token structure of Mess3 makes components easier to distinguish than typical natural language domains, which may make the factored geometry easier to learn than in practice. Our ground-truth belief computation relies on exact analytical updates that are not available for real corpora, so the regression analysis cannot be applied directly to language models without synthetic proxy tasks.

8 Conclusion

A transformer trained on a non-ergodic mixture of Mess3 processes learns a hierarchically factored residual stream geometry: meta-belief π is encoded in a subspace nearly orthogonal to all within-component beliefs η_k, while the η_k subspaces are partially entangled, with overlap 0.53–0.69. Training dynamics show η_k representations emerge an order of magnitude earlier than π (step 100 vs. 2,000). Varying model dimension confirms this hierarchy: the model suppresses π almost entirely at $d = 4$ while maintaining $R^2(\eta_k) > 0.80$, ruling out that the π–η_k orthogonality at $d = 64$ is an artifact of surplus capacity. Future work should test whether these geometric signatures generalise to larger models and richer token alphabets.

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